

Electron-Ion Path Integral Monte Carlo with the Pair-Product Action

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I. INTRODUCTION

Hydrogen is the simplest element in the Universe. On general grounds we expect a plasma of electrons and protons (*ep* plasma) to form clusters of one electron bound to one proton, i.e. Hydrogen atoms. Therefore we expect that a computer experimenter which simulates the *ep* plasma in thermal equilibrium will observe the H atom formation. That this is possible using just the laws of quantum statistical physics and the law of Coulomb has been the subject of many studies starting from the pioneer work of Edwards and Lenard [1, 2]. In this work we worry about the particular many body Monte Carlo [3] simulations. There is an extensive literature on first principle computational studies of the *ep* plasma as a fluid binary mixture [4]. In this work we use the particular path integral Monte Carlo (PIMC) method [5].

If we were to study the non-quantum *ep* binary mixture (also called a two component plasma [6]) we would need to introduce some hard core for the opposite charge particles not to collapse one over the other. This is not necessary if we start from a quantum description since a pair of charges in the plasma must satisfy the cusp condition [7, 8] which prevents the divergence of the pair interaction at contact. From a path integral numerical computation point of view, taking properly into account of the cusp condition allows to calculate the path integral, discretized in the imaginary time, with much less effort than using the bare Coulomb interaction, since it makes possible to choose a much less dense time discretization when approximating the continuum limit.

Both the electron and the proton are spin 1/2 particles so that both species of the *ep* mixture, the identical many electrons and the identical many protons, obey to Fermi-Dirac statistics. In this work we will always compare the realistic case that treats separately the two species as fermions and the artificial case of treating them as bosons. We do this because while the simulations for bosons are exact, the simulations for fermions are affected by the so called 'fermions sign problem' [9]. So the simulations of the realistic case can only be treated with approximate methods. We will here use the restricted path integral Monte Carlo (RPIMC) method with a free particles restriction [10]. The RPIMC method is much more demanding computationally since one has to calculate determinant of order of the

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number of the particles of each species, $N/2$, for each timeslice of the time discretization, after each Metropolis [11] move.

We expect a phase transition from a classical TCP at high temperature, $T > 10^4\text{K}$, to metallic Hydrogen, $10^3\text{K} < T < 10^4\text{K}$, to molecular Hydrogen, $10\text{K} < T < 10^3\text{K}$, to solid Hydrogen at lower temperatures (see figure 4 of Ref. [4] or figure 2 of Ref. [12]). A liquid-liquid phase transition at approximately 500GPa separates the molecular Hydrogen at lower pressures to the atomic Hydrogen at higher pressures. In this work we will use the canonical N, n, T ensemble where n is the number density and will simulate just the two metallic and molecular phases.

II. THE COMPUTER EXPERIMENT

In order to study the quantum statistical properties of the ep fluid binary mixture (H) through a computer experiment it is necessary to add to our simulation box of volume Ω an equal number $N/2$ of electrons (e) of mass m_e , the species 1, and of protons (p) of mass m_p , the species 2, and let them interact with the usual Coulomb pair potential $\pm 1/r$. We thus obtain a fluid of number density $n = N/\Omega$. We can then study the properties of H in thermal equilibrium at an inverse temperature $\beta = 1/k_B T$ with k_B Boltzmann constant and T the absolute temperature. If the laws of quantum statistical physics and of Coulomb are meaningful we should be able to reproduce the thermodynamic and structural properties of H that we observe in nature.

In our reduced units we will measure lengths in units of a Bohr radius $a_B = \hbar^2/m_e e^2$ and energies in units of two Rydbergs e^2/a_B , i.e. of a Hartree. The Hamiltonian operator and the density matrix in reduced units will then read

$$H = K + V = - \sum_{\alpha=1}^N \lambda_{i_\alpha} \nabla_\alpha^2 + \sum_{\alpha < \beta=1}^N \phi_{i_\alpha i_\beta}(r_{\alpha\beta}), \quad (2.1)$$

$$\rho = e^{-H/T}. \quad (2.2)$$

where we indicate with a Greek index the particle label and with a Roman index the species label so that for example i_α is the species label of particle α , either 1 for the electrons or 2 for the protons, $\mathbf{r}_\alpha$ is the position vector of particle α , and $r_{\alpha\beta} = |\mathbf{r}_{\alpha\beta}| = |\mathbf{r}_\alpha - \mathbf{r}_\beta|$ is the distance between particles α and β . The partial pair potential is the usual Coulomb potential $\phi_{ij}(r) = \epsilon_{ij}/r$ with $\epsilon_{ii} = +1$ for all i and $\epsilon_{ij} = -1$ for $i \neq j$. $\lambda_i = \hbar^2/2\mu_i$ where the reduced masses are $\mu_1 = 1$ and $\mu_2 = m_p/m_e \approx 1836.15$. Temperatures are in units of $\mathcal{T} \approx 315775\text{K}$.

The coordinate representation of the high temperature density matrix for distinguishable particles is [5]

$$\rho(R, R'; \tau) = \rho_0(R, R'; \tau) e^{-U(R, R'; \tau)}, \quad (2.3)$$

$$\rho_0(R, R'; \tau) = \prod_{\alpha=1}^N (4\pi\lambda_{i_\alpha}\tau)^{-3/2} e^{-(\mathbf{r}_\alpha - \mathbf{r}'_\alpha)^2/4\lambda_{i_\alpha}\tau}, \quad (2.4)$$

where ρ_0 is the high temperature free density matrix and $\tau = \beta/M$ for large M . So that the coordinate representation of the thermal density matrix for identical particles can be obtained from the following discretized path integral [10]

$$\rho(R, R'; \beta) = \sum_{\mathcal{P}} \text{sgn}(\mathcal{P}) \int \rho(\mathcal{P}R, R_1; \tau) \rho(R_1, R_2; \tau) \cdots \rho(R_{M-1}, R'; \tau) \prod_{k=1}^{M-1} dR_k, \quad (2.5)$$

where $R_k = (\mathbf{r}_{1,k}, \mathbf{r}_{2,k}, \dots, \mathbf{r}_{N,k})$ is the k th timeslice. Here $\mathbf{r}_{\alpha,k}$ is the position vector of particle α of species i_α at timeslice k in the path integral. Each high temperature density matrix gives a *link* between two successive *timeslices*. The sum is over the permutations $\mathcal{P}$ of identical particles (of the same species) and $\text{sgn}(\mathcal{P})$ is the sign of the given permutation

$$\text{sgn}(\mathcal{P}) = \begin{cases} +1 & \text{Bose-Einstein statistics} \\ \begin{cases} +1 & \mathcal{P} \text{ an even permutation} \\ -1 & \mathcal{P} \text{ an odd permutation} \end{cases} & \text{Fermi-Dirac statistics} \end{cases} \quad (2.6)$$

While a Monte Carlo integration [3] of the path integral (2.5) (PIMC) can be carried out exactly for bosons, for fermions the alternating signs in the permutation sum becomes less and less efficient as N and/or M increase [9]. This is known as the ‘fermions sign problem’. An approximate way to circumvent this problem is the Restricted Path Integral Monte Carlo (RPIMC) method of Ceperley [9, 10]. In our simulations we will always compare the PIMC for bosons and the RPIMC for fermions with a free fermions restriction. Of course the Bose-Einstein case is not realistic but we offer it just as a theoretical and exact calculation.

For the inter-action U we will adopt the end-point approximation for the pair-product action [5]

$$U(R, R'; \tau) \approx \sum_{\alpha < \beta} P_{i_\alpha i_\beta}(\mathbf{r}_{\alpha\beta}, \mathbf{r}_{\alpha\beta}; \tau), \quad (2.7)$$

where for P_{ij} we choose the pair Coulomb density matrix of Pollock [8]. Namely

$$P_{ij}(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}'; \tau) = -\ln \left[\frac{\rho_{ij}(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}'; \tau)}{\rho_{ij}^0(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}'; \tau)} \right], \quad (2.8)$$

where

$$\frac{\partial \rho_{ij}(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}'; \tau)}{\partial \tau} = \left[\lambda_{ij} \nabla - \frac{\epsilon_{ij}}{r} \right] \rho_{ij}(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}'; \tau). \quad (2.9)$$

Here $\lambda_{ij} = \lambda_i + \lambda_j$ and $\rho_{ij}^0(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}'; \tau) = (4\pi\lambda_{ij}\tau)^{-3/2} \exp[-(\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}')^2/4\lambda_{ij}\tau]$ satisfies the same Eq. (2.9) but for $\epsilon_{ij} = 0$ for all i, j .

In a PIMC computer experiment one needs to worry about two limiting procedures: i. the thermodynamic $N \rightarrow \infty$ limit and ii. the continuum $M \rightarrow \infty$ limit. The simulation box of volume $\Omega = L^3$ can be made periodic so that it permeates the whole infinite three dimensional space in order to mimic the thermodynamic limit. This will produce finite size errors that can be reduced by increasing the box size L . Of course in order to study a given thermodynamic state of the system this requires increasing L at constant density n which means increasing N . This will make the computer experiment more demanding from the numerical calculation cost point of view. Moreover, in periodic boundary conditions the potential energy V for the particles within the central box should include also the pair interactions with all their images in the periodic boxes. Since the Coulomb potential $1/r$ is long range these contributions cannot generally be neglected and specific techniques should be used [13] to treat them, the most common of which is the Ewald summation. In this work we will neglect interactions with periodic images and we use the end-point approximation for the pair-product action. The continuum limit requires an M sufficiently large for the characteristic size of a free link of each species be much smaller than the box side, i.e. $\sigma_i = \sqrt{2\lambda_i\tau} \ll L$ for all i , so that we can neglect the periodic copies of the high temperature free density matrix.

It is often useful to introduce the Wigner-Seitz radius r_s for the electron component, i.e. the reduced mean interelectron distance $r_s = (4\pi n_1/3)^{-1/3}$ with $n_1 = n/2$. If we rescale each reduced coordinate as $\tilde{\mathbf{r}}_\alpha = \mathbf{r}_\alpha/r_s$. Then the rescaled kinetic energy, $\tilde{K} = r_s^2 K$ and the rescaled potential energy, $\tilde{V} = r_s V$. We then see that as n increases, r_s decreases, V is penalized respect to K , and the mixture tends to behave like a non interacting one, with less correlations. This is confirmed by our numerical experiments.

We performed some computer experiments as described in Table I. During the simulations we measured some thermodynamic quantities as the total kinetic and potential energy of the ep plasma and the superfluid fractions for each species. These were measured using the thermodynamic estimators described in Ref. [5]. And we also calculated the partial and total Radial Distribution Functions (RDF) [14]. Given an observable $\mathcal{O}$ we can measure it during the simulation through the following PIMC operation [5]

$$\langle \mathcal{O} \rangle = \text{tr}(\rho \mathcal{O})/Z, \quad (2.10)$$

$$Z = \text{tr}(\rho), \quad (2.11)$$

where ρ is the density matrix of Eq. (2.5), $\text{tr}(\dots)$ is the trace operation, and Z is the canonical partition function. Therefore we impose both spatial and imaginary time periodic boundary conditions for the many body path of both species $R(t) = (\mathbf{r}_1(t), \mathbf{r}_2(t), \dots, \mathbf{r}_N(t))$ where $t \in [0, \beta[$ is the imaginary time. So that for any function f we require $f(R + L\mathbf{u}) = f(R)$ with $\mathbf{u}$ a unit vector along any of the $3N$ dimensions and $R(t + \beta) = R(t)$. Our algorithm is discussed in the Appendix A.

For each thermodynamic state considered we compared the two cases where we treat the like particles first as bosons and then as fermions. Comparing the reduced de Broglie thermal wavelength of each species, $\Lambda_i = \sqrt{1/T\mu_i}$, with the interparticle spacing, $(n/2)^{-1/3}$, we may define a reduced degeneracy temperature, $T_i^D = (n/2)^{2/3}/\mu_i$, for each species. For temperatures higher than the degeneracy temperature, quantum statistics, either bosonic or fermionic, are not very important. Note that the difference between the two statistics for the heavy and slow protons component is driven by the light and fast electrons component which ‘dress’ the protons.

In Fig. 2 we compare the end-point approximation for the pair-product action (see section IV.F of Ref. [5]) constructed with the pair Coulomb density matrix of Pollock [8] with the bare Coulomb potential that enters the primitive approximation to the action. The figure shows how $P_{ij}(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}; \tau)$ from the pair Coulomb density matrix (2.8) does not diverge to $\pm\infty$ for $r \rightarrow 0$ but satisfies a cusp condition instead. The cusp condition can be easily determined studying the asymptotic behavior at small r of a vanishing residual energy for the pair-product approximation to the

TABLE I. Cases treated in our simulations for the ep fluid mixture. We show the total number of particles N , the reduced number density $n = N/\Omega$, the reduced temperature T , the total kinetic energy per particle $e_K = \langle K \rangle/N$, the total potential energy per particle $e_V = \langle V \rangle/N$, the superfluid fraction for species i , $f_s(i)$. In the statistics column “b” stands for bosons, “f” for fermions. The simulation lasted more than 10^8 Monte Carlo steps. In all cases $\tau \approx 0.3$.

case	statistics	T	M	n	N	Ne_K	$-Ne_V$	$f_s(1)$	$f_s(2)$
A	b (PIMC)	0.15	20	0.3	30	10.44(1)	20.88(1)	0.596(1)	0.04774(7)
B	f (RPIMC)	0.15	20	0.3	20	6.2(2)	13.83(5)	0.72(6)	0.0475(3)
C	b (PIMC)	0.15	20	0.16	30	9.83(1)	19.55(2)	0.486(2)	0.04783(7)
D	f (RPIMC)	0.15	20	0.16	20	5.4(1)	12.06(5)	0.64(5)	0.0477(3)
E	b (PIMC)	0.03	111	0.16	30				
F	f (RPIMC)	0.03	111	0.16	30				

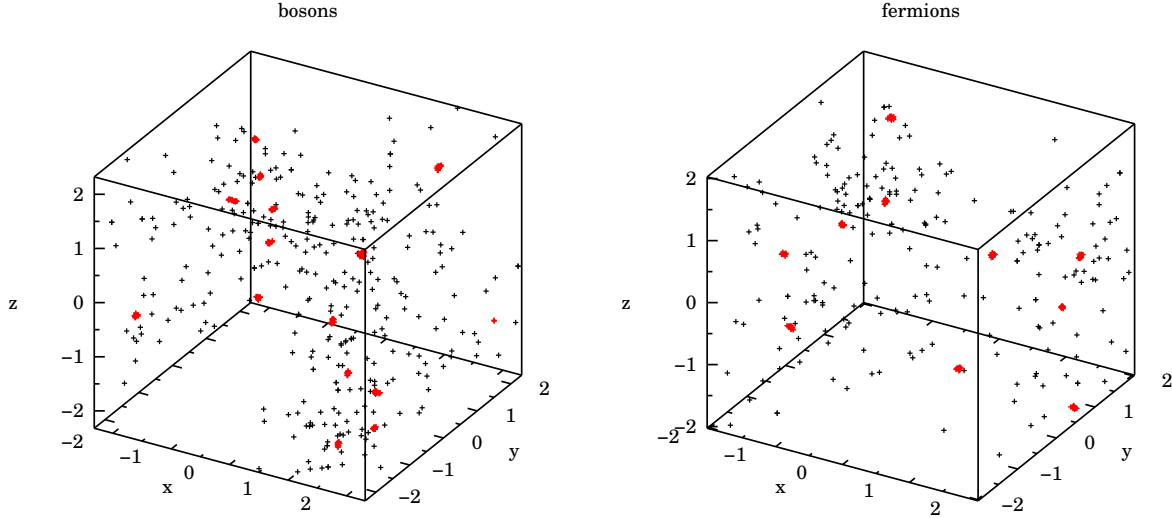


FIG. 1. Snapshots of the simulations for cases A (bosons) and B (fermions) at equilibrium. Red points are for the heavy slow protons and black points are for the light fast electrons. Each point represents the coordinates of the given species at each timeslice along the path. We see how bosons like to stay together while fermions like to stay apart.

action [5]. Clearly this is a purely quantum effect and it allows to avoid the use of an artificial hard core for the proton species.

In Fig. 1 we show snapshots of the simulations for the bosons and fermions cases at equilibrium. We clearly see how the bosons tend to like themselves while the fermions dislike themselves.

In Figs. 3 and 4 we show the RDF’s for the case studies of Table I. From the like RDF we clearly see how the ee component has the expected exchange hole in the fermions. Nonetheless we see that $g_{ee}(0) \neq 0$ due to our approximate free particle restriction (see Appendix A). The ep component has a large peak at contact which signals the H atom formation. The pp component has a large first peak at $r \approx 1.25$ signaling the the H_2 molecule formation. As the density is lowered at a constant low temperature, the peaks increase in magnitude and the difference between the Bose and Fermi cases increases, as expected. In the D Fermi case the pp component shows some oscillations in the part of the RDF descending from the first peak which may indicate the formation of H_2 molecules of different interatomic distances.

With $M = 20$ timeslices we found that the mixture collapses at temperatures lower than ≈ 0.15 . In order to simulate the interior of planets like Jupiter or Saturn we should be able to treat reduced temperature as low as $T \approx 10^4/\mathcal{T} \approx 0.03$. To reach these temperatures without facing collapse it is necessary to keep τ constant ($\tau = 0.3$ requires $M \approx 111$ for example). We then considered cases E and F of Table I. The RDF’s are shown in Fig. 5. As we can see the mixture doe not collapse and reaches thermal equilibrium in a molecular H_2 fluid.

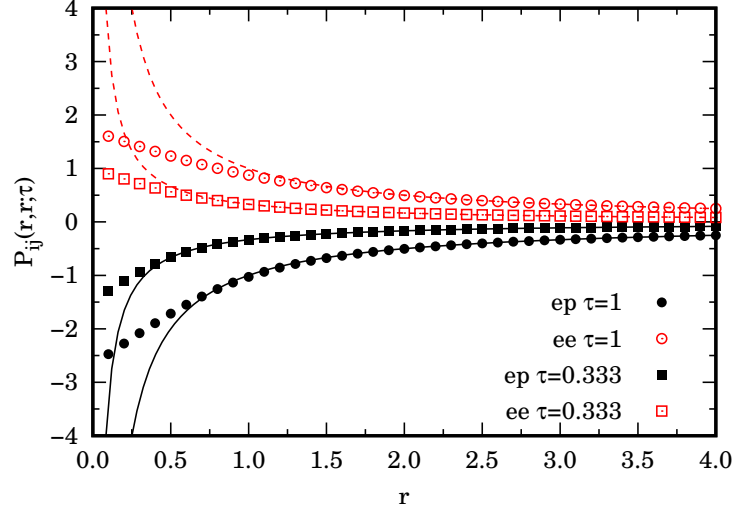


FIG. 2. We show the ee and ep components of $P_{ij}(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}; \tau)$ of Eq. (2.8) for two values of τ (dots). We compare it with the bare Coulomb potential $\tau\epsilon_{ij}/r$ (lines). From the figure we can see that the cusp condition [8] $P_{ij}(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}; \tau) \sim r\epsilon_{ij}/2\lambda_{ij}$ is satisfied at small r . The distance r is in units of a Bohr radius.

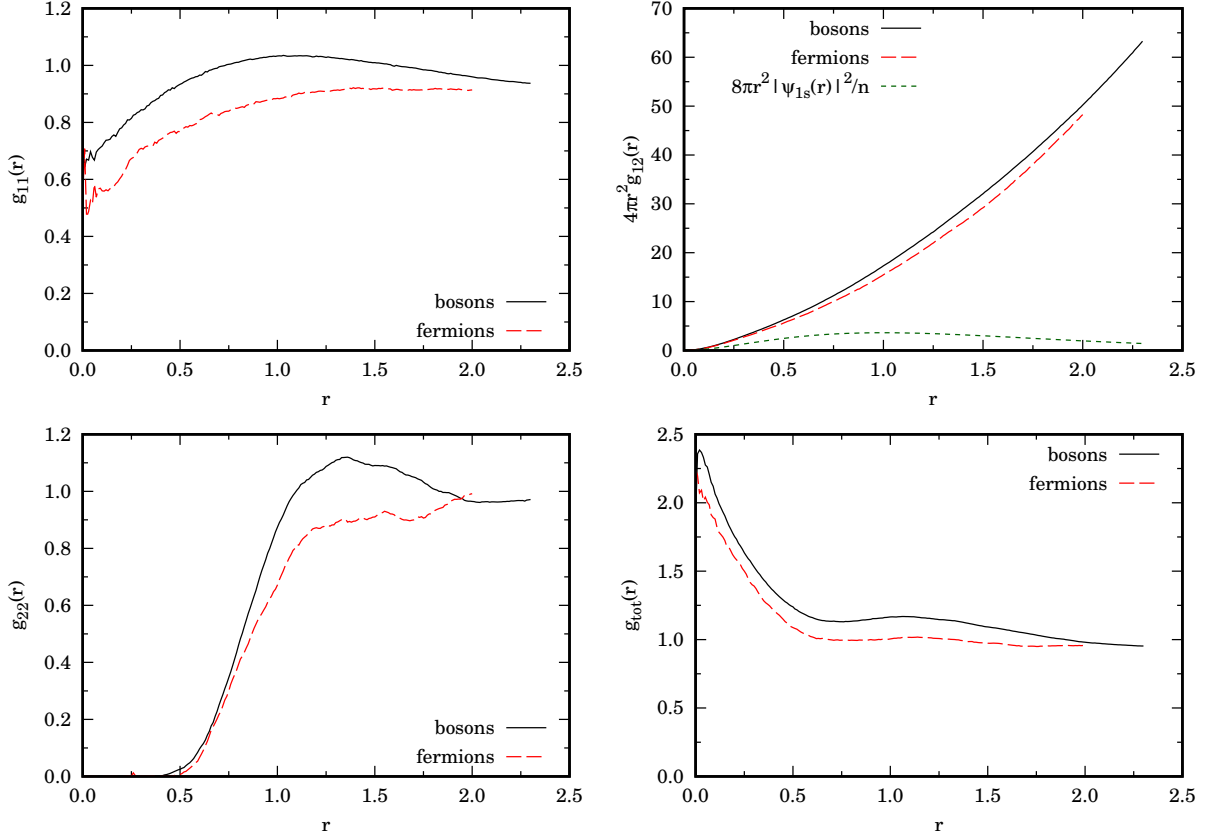


FIG. 3. We show the partial and total RDF of the H fluid for cases A and B in Table I where $\tau = 0.333$. In the panel for the unlike radial distribution function we also show the ground state probability distribution of the H atom $|\psi_{1s}|^2$ for comparison. The distance r is in units of a Bohr radius.

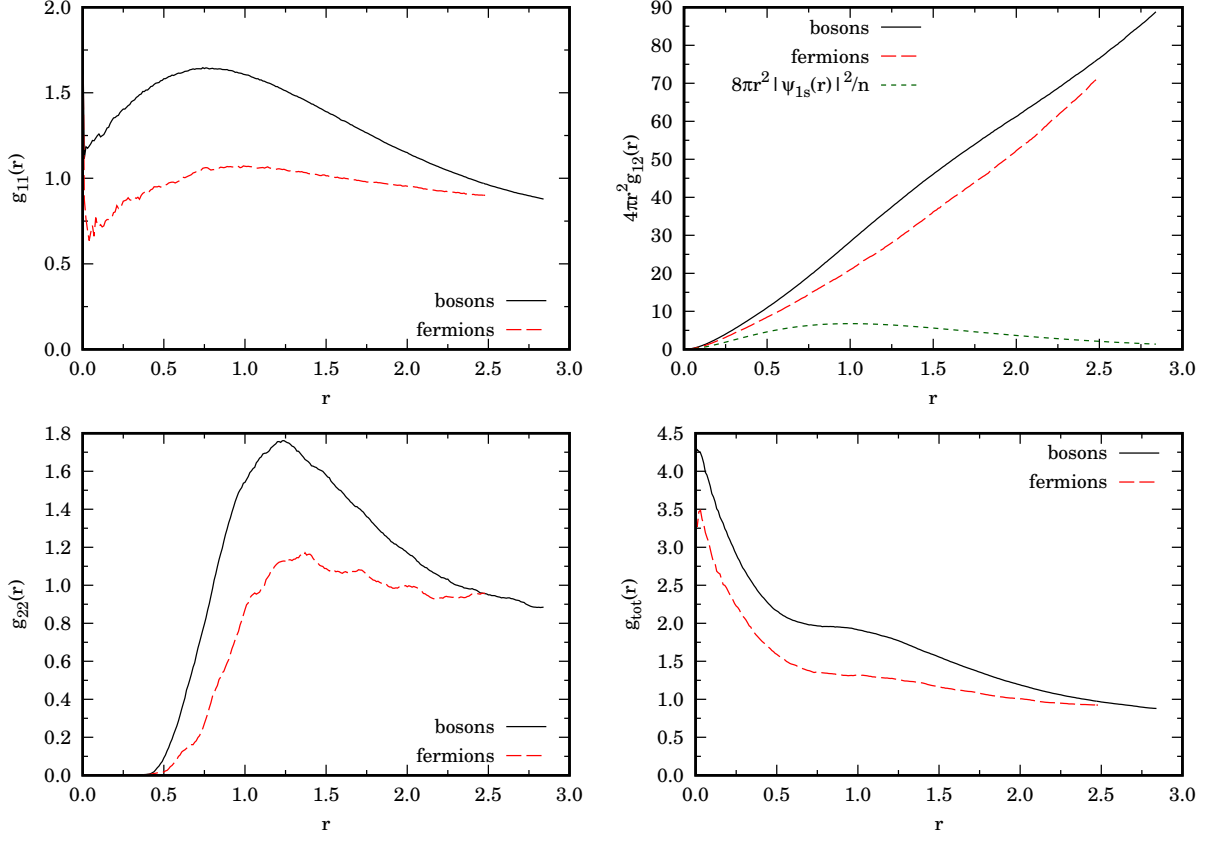


FIG. 4. We show the partial and total RDF of the H fluid for cases C and D in Table I where $\tau = 0.333$. In the panel for the unlike radial distribution function we also show the ground state probability distribution of the H atom $|\psi_{1s}|^2$ for comparison. The distance r is in units of a Bohr radius.

III. CONCLUSIONS

In summary, we studied the ep binary mixture through (R)PIMC to extract thermodynamic and structural properties of the plasma in thermal equilibrium. In order to approach the continuum limit with less number of timeslices we used the pair-product Coulomb action within the end-point approximation.

Our RDF should be compared with Fig. 16 of Ref. [4] where they found, using the coupled electron-ions PIMC (CEIMC), some evidence for the H_2 molecule formation at $T = 1200\text{K}/\mathcal{T} \approx 3.80017 \times 10^{-3}$ and $r_s = 1.44$ which means $n \approx 0.159902$. It is interesting to compare the two approaches to see where CEIMC may need to be corrected by a treatment of the mixture as a whole with no need to separate the simulation of the electrons from the one of the protons.

When studying the real ep mixture which requires to treat electrons and protons as fermions we use the RPIMC approximate method with a free particles restriction in order to overcome the ‘fermions sign problem’. This is necessary to reduce the complexity of the algorithm from exponential in the number of fermions to polynomial [10, 15]. We always compared the realistic mixture with the mixture obtained treating the particles as bosons for which the PIMC is exact and polynomial in the number of bosons.

Appendix A: Description of our PIMC and RPIMC algorithms

Given the order $N/2$ determinant

$$D_i^0(k_1, k_2) = \det \left\| (4\pi\lambda_i |k_1 - k_2| \tau)^{-3/2} e^{-(\mathbf{r}_{\alpha, k_1} - \mathbf{r}_{\beta, k_2})^2 / 4\lambda_i |k_1 - k_2| \tau} \right\|_{\alpha\beta}, \quad (\text{A1})$$

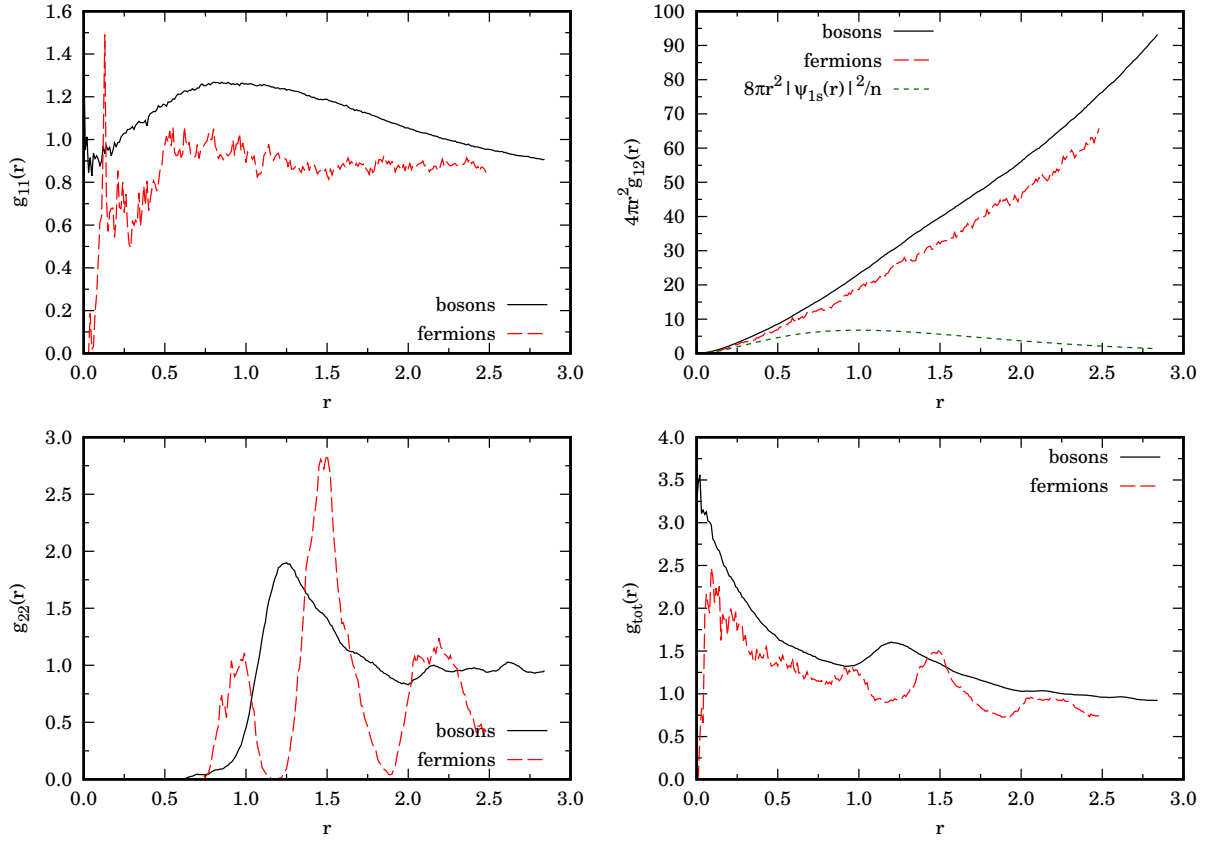


FIG. 5. We show the partial and total RDF of the H fluid for cases E and F in Table I where $\tau = 0.3$. In the panel for the unlike radial distribution function we also show the ground state probability distribution of the H atom $|\psi_{1s}|^2$ for comparison. The distance r is in units of a Bohr radius.

such that $i_\alpha = i_\beta = i$, in the RPIMC with free particles restriction we reject the move whenever it produces a change of sign in the product $D_1^0(k_0, k)D_2^0(k_0, k)$ calculated between a reference timeslice k_0 (which may be chosen at random) and any other timeslice $k = 1, 2, \dots, M - 1$ [9]. Of course this method is exact only for free fermions. For our ep mixture it is just an approximation.

AUTHOR DECLARATIONS

Conflicts of interest

None declared.

Data availability

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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